Design Advisor Skill Guide

Build a Claude Code skill that gives you professional design recommendations for any industry in 10 seconds. 550+ design rules, 100 industry palettes, real 21st.dev component examples.

Section 1: Set Up Claude Code

Before you can build the design advisor skill, you need Claude Code running in VS Code. If you already have it installed, skip to Section 2.

Install VS Code

1. Open your browser and go to **code.visualstudio.com**
2. Click the big blue **Download** button for your operating system (Mac, Windows, or Linux)
3. Open the downloaded file and follow the installer steps
4. When it's done, open VS Code. You'll see a welcome screen with a dark editor

Install the Claude Code Extension

1. In VS Code, look at the left sidebar. Click the **Extensions** icon (it looks like four small squares)
2. In the search bar at the top, type **Claude Code**
3. Find the extension published by **Anthropic** (the company that makes Claude)
4. Click the blue **Install** button
5. Wait about 10 seconds for it to finish

Sign In

1. After installing, you'll see a new Claude Code icon in your left sidebar. Click it.
2. Click **Sign In** and follow the prompts to create or log into your Anthropic account
3. Once signed in, you'll see a chat panel where you can type messages to Claude

Verify It Works

Type a simple test message in the Claude Code panel:

```
What is 2 + 2?
```

If Claude responds with "4", you're good to go. Claude Code is installed and working.

Section 2: Create the Skill File

Skills in Claude Code are instructions that tell Claude how to handle a specific type of request. When you type `/design` in the chat, Claude reads the skill file and follows those instructions.

Create the Directory

1. In VS Code, open the file explorer (click the folder icon in the left sidebar)
2. Right-click on your project folder and select **New Folder**
3. Name it `.claude` (with the dot at the beginning)
4. Inside `.claude`, create another folder called `skills`
5. Inside `skills`, create another folder called `design`

Your folder structure should look like this:

```
your-project/
  .claude/
    skills/
      design/
        SKILL.md      ← you'll create this next
        data/          ← you'll add CSV files here in Section 3
```

Write the SKILL.md File

1. Right-click on the `design` folder and select **New File**
2. Name it `SKILL.md`
3. Paste the following content into the file:

```
# Design Advisor

## Overview
A design advisor skill that provides industry-specific UI/UX recommendations
before building. Searches design data files to give actionable recommendations
with hex codes, font pairings, layout patterns, and anti-pattern warnings.

## Workflow
1. Identify the industry/product type from the user's request
2. Search relevant CSV data files in .claude/skills/design/data/
3. Cross-reference with design vocabulary for proper terminology
4. Search 21st.dev for real component examples (if MCP available)
5. Present structured recommendations with implementation details

## Data Files
Search these CSV files based on what the user needs:
- colors.csv — industry color palettes (primary, secondary, CTA, bg, text, border)
- typography.csv — font pairings with mood, use cases, Google Fonts links
- ui-reasoning.csv — industry design patterns, anti-patterns, severity
- styles.csv — visual design styles and implementation details
- landing.csv — landing page layout patterns and CTA strategies
- ux-guidelines.csv — UX do/don't rules with code examples
- charts.csv — data visualization recommendations

## Output Format
Structure your response as:
- Style Direction (recommended visual style and why)
- Color Palette (hex codes with roles)
- Typography (font pairing with Google Fonts link)
- Page Structure (section order and CTA placement)
- Key Effects (animations and interactions)
- Anti-Patterns (what to avoid, with severity)
- 21st.dev Examples (real components, if MCP available)
- Next Step (a /ui command to start building)
```

4. Save the file (Cmd+S on Mac, Ctrl+S on Windows)

Test the Skill

Type `/design` in the Claude Code chat panel. If Claude responds asking what you'd like design advice on, the skill file is loading correctly. It won't have any data yet (that's Section 3), but the skill structure is working.

Section 3: Build the Design Database

The power of this skill comes from 7 CSV data files. Each file covers a different aspect of design. Claude searches these files when you run `/design` to give you specific, actionable recommendations.

Create the Data Directory

1. Inside your `.claude/skills/design/` folder, create a new folder called `data`
2. You'll create 7 CSV files inside this folder

The 7 Data Files

Here's what each file does and how to start building it:

File	Purpose	Key Columns
`colors.csv`	Industry color palettes	product_type, primary, secondary, cta, background, text, border
`typography.csv`	Font pairings	name, category, heading_font, body_font, mood, best_for, google_fonts_url
`ui-reasoning.csv`	Industry design patterns	product_type, recommended_style, color_mood, typography_mood, key_effects, anti_patterns, severity
`styles.csv`	Visual design styles	name, description, implementation, use_cases, do_examples, dont_examples
`landing.csv`	Landing page layouts	pattern_name, section_order, cta_placement, color_strategy, effects, conversion_tips
`ux-guidelines.csv`	UX rules	category, rule, do_pattern, do_code, dont_pattern, dont_code, severity
`charts.csv`	Data visualization	data_type, best_chart, colors, accessibility, library

Start with colors.csv

Create `data/colors.csv` and add this header row:

```
product_type,primary,secondary,cta,background,text,border
```

Then add rows for each industry. Here are some examples to get you started:

```
SaaS (General),#2563EB,#3B82F6,#F97316,#F8FAFC,#1E293B,#E2E8F0
E-commerce (Fashion),#059669,#10B981,#F97316,#ECFDF5,#064E3B,#A7F3D0
Fintech/Crypto,#6366F1,#818CF8,#F59E0B,#0F172A,#F8FAFC,#334155
Healthcare App,#0891B2,#22D3EE,#059669,#ECFEFF,#164E63,#A5F3FC
Restaurant/Food,#DC2626,#F87171,#F59E0B,#FEF2F2,#7F1D1D,#FECACA
Luxury/Premium,#1C1917,#44403C,#CA8A04,#FAFAF9,#0C0A09,#D6D3D1
```

Each row gives Claude 6 hex codes with clear roles. When someone asks for a SaaS design, Claude pulls the SaaS row and gives them the exact palette.

Build the Other Files

Follow the same pattern for each file. Start with 10-20 rows in each file and add more over time. The skill gets more accurate with more data.

For `typography.csv`:

```
name,category,heading_font,body_font,mood,best_for,google_fonts_url
Classic Elegant,Serif + Sans,Playfair Display,Inter,luxury elegant refined,luxury fashion
spa editorial,https://fonts.google.com/share?selection.family=Playfair+Display|Inter
Tech Startup,Sans + Sans,Space Grotesk,DM Sans,modern innovative clean,tech companies
startups SaaS,https://fonts.google.com/share?selection.family=Space+Grotesk|DM+Sans
Developer Mono,Mono + Sans,JetBrains Mono,IBM Plex Sans,technical precise
focused,developer tools code editors,https://fonts.google.com/share?
selection.family=JetBrains+Mono|IBM+Plex+Sans
```

For `ui-reasoning.csv`:

```
product_type,recommended_style,color_mood,typography_mood,key_effects,anti_patterns,severit
SaaS (General),Hero + Features + CTA,Trust blue + Orange CTA,Clean
geometric,Glassmorphism cards hover lift,Cluttered hero with too many CTAs,HIGH
Fintech/Crypto,Conversion-Optimized,Deep purple + Amber accents,Modern sans-serif,Dark
mode glassmorphism,Light backgrounds reduce trust,MEDIUM
Restaurant/Food,Menu-First Visual,Warm red + Gold accents,Friendly rounded,Food
photography parallax,Stock photos instead of real food,HIGH
```

Section 4: Industry Color Palettes

The `colors.csv` file is the foundation. When someone runs `/design` for a specific industry, the first thing Claude returns is the color palette.

How It Works

Each row in `colors.csv` maps an industry type to 6 colors:

- **Primary** — the main brand color, used for headers and key UI elements
- **Secondary** — a supporting color, used for hover states and secondary buttons
- **CTA** — the call-to-action color, used for buttons and links that need attention
- **Background** — the page background color
- **Text** — the main body text color
- **Border** — used for card borders, dividers, and subtle outlines

Why 6 Roles Matter

Most people pick 2-3 colors and call it a day. But having exactly 6 roles means Claude can tell you not just "use blue" but "use #2563EB for your headers, #3B82F6 for hover states, #F97316 for your CTA button, and here's why that orange CTA works against the blue: it creates a complementary contrast that draws the eye."

Adding Your Own Industry

If your industry isn't in the file, add a new row:

```
Your Industry,#hex1,#hex2,#hex3,#hex4,#hex5,#hex6
```

Pick colors by looking at the top 5 companies in that industry. Find the common patterns (most fintech uses dark backgrounds with purple/blue primaries, most healthcare uses teal/cyan with green CTAs). The pattern becomes your row.

Section 5: Typography Pairings

The `typography.csv` file gives Claude 57 font pairings to choose from. Each pairing is a heading font + body font combination with a mood and use case.

Why Font Pairing Matters

The wrong font pairing makes a professional product look amateur. A SaaS dashboard using Playfair Display (a serif font) looks like a wedding invitation. A luxury brand using Comic Sans is a meme.

Claude matches the font pairing to your industry's mood:

- **SaaS/Tech** → clean, geometric sans-serif (Space Grotesk + DM Sans)
- **Luxury/Fashion** → elegant serif + clean sans (Playfair Display + Inter)
- **Developer Tools** → monospace + technical sans (JetBrains Mono + IBM Plex Sans)

Every Row Includes

- The pairing name (e.g., "Classic Elegant")
- Category (Serif + Sans, Sans + Sans, Display + Sans, Mono)
- Both font names (heading + body)
- Mood keywords
- Best-for use cases
- A ready-to-use Google Fonts URL (one click to add both fonts)
- Tailwind config (optional, for developers)

Using the Recommendations

When Claude recommends a font pairing, it gives you the Google Fonts URL. Click it, click "Get embed code", and paste the link tag into your HTML. The fonts are free and load fast.

Section 6: Layout and UX Rules

Three files work together to give you layout recommendations and warn you about mistakes:

landing.csv — Page Structure

30+ landing page patterns with:

- Section order (e.g., "Hero → Features → Testimonials → Pricing → CTA")
- CTA placement strategy (above fold, after proof, floating)
- Color strategy per section
- Conversion optimization tips

Example: the "Hero + Features + CTA" pattern works for most SaaS products. The "Before-After Transformation" pattern works for fitness, coaching, and consulting. Claude picks the right pattern for your industry.

ux-guidelines.csv — Do/Don't Rules

100 UX rules organized by category:

- Navigation (smooth scroll, sticky nav, breadcrumbs)
- Animation (motion sickness, duration, reduced motion)
- Forms (labels, error placement, validation)
- Accessibility (contrast ratios, keyboard nav, screen readers)
- Performance (image optimization, lazy loading)

Each rule has a "Do" pattern with code and a "Don't" pattern with code, plus a severity level (HIGH, MEDIUM, LOW). Claude flags the HIGH severity anti-patterns first.

ui-reasoning.csv — Industry Anti-Patterns

100 industry-specific design patterns that tell Claude what NOT to do. For example:

- Fintech: don't use light backgrounds (reduces trust perception)

- Restaurants: don't use stock food photos (kills authenticity)
- Healthcare: don't use red as a primary color (triggers anxiety)

These are the mistakes that even experienced designers make. Claude catches them before you build.

Section 7: Connect 21st.dev MCP

This is what takes the skill from "good recommendations" to "here are real components you can use." 21st.dev is a component library with thousands of React components. The MCP (Model Context Protocol) connection lets Claude search 21st.dev and show you real examples.

What is 21st.dev?

21st.dev is a library of production-ready React components. When Claude recommends a "glassmorphic hero section for SaaS," it can search 21st.dev and show you 3-5 real hero components that match. Not mockups. Real, working code you can copy.

Install the MCP Server

1. In VS Code, open Claude Code settings (click the gear icon in the Claude Code panel)
2. Look for the MCP servers section
3. Add the 21st.dev MCP server. The configuration looks like this:

```
{
  "mcpServers": {
    "magic": {
      "command": "npx",
      "args": ["-y", "@21st-dev/magic@latest"],
      "env": {
        "TWENTY_FIRST_API_KEY": "your-api-key-here"
      }
    }
  }
}
```

4. Get your API key from 21st.dev (sign up for a free account)
5. Replace `your-api-key-here` with your actual API key
6. Save and restart Claude Code

Verify the Connection

Type `/design` and ask for a landing page recommendation. If you see real component examples from 21st.dev in the response, the MCP is connected.

If you don't see 21st.dev examples, the skill still works. It just gives recommendations without the visual examples. You can always browse 21st.dev manually using the component names Claude recommends.

Section 8: Run Your First Design Audit

Everything is set up. Time to run your first design audit.

Step 1: Open Claude Code

Open VS Code and click the Claude Code panel in the left sidebar.

Step 2: Type Your Request

Type `/design` followed by what you're building. Be specific about your industry:

```
/design landing page for a SaaS project management tool
```

Or:

```
/design dashboard for a fintech portfolio tracker
```

Or:

```
/design homepage for a local restaurant
```

Step 3: Read the Output

Claude will return a structured design brief:

1. **Style Direction** — the recommended visual style (e.g., "Glassmorphism with dark mode")
2. **Color Palette** — 6 hex codes with roles and contrast ratios
3. **Typography** — font pairing with Google Fonts link
4. **Page Structure** — section order and CTA placement
5. **Key Effects** — animations and interactions that fit
6. **Anti-Patterns** — what to avoid (with severity badges)
7. **21st.dev Examples** — real components (if MCP is connected)
8. **Next Step** — a `/ui` command to start building

Step 4: Use the Recommendations

Copy the hex codes into your CSS or Tailwind config. Click the Google Fonts link to add the fonts. Follow the page structure. Avoid the anti-patterns.

If you want to generate the actual component, use the `/ui` command that Claude suggests at the bottom of the design brief. This uses 21st.dev to build a real React component based on the design recommendations.

Section 9: Customize for Your Industry

The skill gets better as you add more data. Here's how to customize it for your specific needs.

Add a New Industry

If your industry isn't in the CSV files, add a row to each relevant file:

1. **colors.csv** — research the top 5 companies in your industry. Find the common color patterns. Create a 6-color palette.
2. **typography.csv** — look at what fonts the industry leaders use. Find a heading + body pairing that matches the mood.
3. **ui-reasoning.csv** — identify the design mistakes common in your industry. Add them as anti-patterns with severity levels.

Adjust Existing Recommendations

If Claude's recommendations don't quite fit your project, you can:

1. Edit the CSV row for your industry type
2. Add a brand override in your skill file (e.g., "When the user's project is [name], always use [color]")
3. Ask Claude to adjust: "/design landing page for SaaS, but use our brand color #FF6B00 instead of the default"

Track What Works

Over time, you'll notice which recommendations lead to the best results. Update the CSV data based on what actually converts. The skill learns from your edits.

Section 10: Next Steps

You now have a working design advisor skill in Claude Code. Here's where to go from here:

The /design → /ui Workflow

1. Run `/design` to get recommendations
2. Pick the style, colors, and layout you want
3. Run `/ui` with your specifications to generate the actual component

4. Drop the component into your project

This two-step workflow replaces hours of design decision-making with minutes of automated recommendations followed by generated code.

Keep Building Your Database

The more rows in your CSV files, the more accurate the recommendations. Start with 10-20 rows per file and grow to 50-100 over time. The skill scales with your data.

Share Your Data

If you build a comprehensive design database, you can share the CSV files with other Claude Code users. The skill file is the same for everyone. The data is what makes it unique.

Get More Claude Code Skills

This is one of many skills you can build in Claude Code. For more content like this, follow @KyleWhitrow on Instagram and comment **DESIGN** on any post to get this guide sent to your DMs.

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Send an email to **kyle@nustimulus.com** for inquiries.

nustimulus.com